



Linguistic Background

An Outline of English Syntax

CSE

Ho Chi Minh City University of Technology

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Outline

- 1 Words
- 2 Simple noun phrases
- 3 Verb phrases and simple sentences
- 4 Noun phrases revisited
- 5 Adjective Phrases
- 6 Adverbial Phrases



Words

Words

Simple noun
phrases

Verb phrases and
simple sentences

Noun phrases
revisited

Adjective Phrases

Adverbial Phrases

- Word is a basic unit of linguistic structure, which is formed from more basic units.
- There are two ways that new words are formed: Inflectional form, Derivational form.

Inflectional form: **root + suffix**

Exp : write+s = writes

Derivational form: **new word is formed**

Exp: friend+ly = friendly (adj)

friend + liness = friendliness (noun)



Word Category

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Words are divided into different categories based on word's role:

- word's contribution to meaning of the phrase in which word is obtained or
- the syntactic structure, in which word may play a role.

Example: green (adjective) book (noun) <-> the green (noun) is lighter than the other; book (modifier) worm (con mọt sách)

- 4 main categories: noun, adjective, verb, adverb. Besides, pronoun, preposition, article, etc.

Word phrase: head word + word components

There are main word phrases: noun phrase, verb phrase, adjective phrase, preposition phrase.



Simple noun phrases

Words

**Simple noun
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The simplest noun phrase has only one word: pronoun *she*, *he*.

Noun phrases contain proper noun, common noun (count, mass)

Words preceding head are specifier, qualifier.



Verb phrases and simple sentences

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Mood of sentence: assert, query, command.

Sentence has noun phrase (NP)- the subject, followed by
verb phrase (VP)- the predicate



Verb

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Verb occurs in one of the five forms: base, simple present, simple past, present participle (động tính từ hiện tại), past participle (động tính từ quá khứ), future, progress

- Verb can be divided into 3 classes: main, auxiliary, modal
- Verb has 2 forms: active, passive
- Some verb forms are constructed from a verb and additional word called **particle**, exp: **put on**, **look up**
- Tense system: simple present, simple past, simple future, present perfect, present progressive



Verb (cont.)

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- Transitive and intransitive verb. Intransitive verb may stand alone with no complement (run, laugh). Transitive verbs have complement form requires a noun phrase to follow the verb.
- Transitive verb allow another form of verb group, called passive form, Example: I was hit by them (active form: they hit me).
- Some verbs allow two noun phrases (NPs) to follow them in the sentence, such as give, find; the first NP is **direct** object, the second is **indirect** object. The indirect object appears with preposition.



Verb (cont.)

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- Example: “Jack gives the book to me”; “Jack found a key for me”.
- Some verb forms are constructed from verb and an additional word called a **particle**
- Particle generally overlap with the class of prepositions, such as: up, in, over, out. Example: put on, take out
- The sharp distinction between particle and preposition is when object of the verb is pronoun; particle may precedes or also follows the object NP, this is not allowed with preposition.



Clausal Complements

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Many verbs allow clauses as complements. Clauses share most of the same properties of sentences and have subject, indicate tense, occur in passivized forms.

- One clause form consists sentence form preceded by word that.
- Clause form may involve the infinitive form of the verb. The VP[inf] is simple clause, VP starting in infinitive form.
- Another important class of clauses are sentences with complementize wh-word: who, which, what, where, why, whether.



Prepositional Phrase complements

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Many verbs require complement s that involve specific prepositional phrases (PP).

Example: verb **give** takes the complements NP and PP with preposition in: “Jack gave the book (NP) to the library (PP)”.

- There are prepositional phrase to indicate location and to indicate a path of motion.



Noun phrases revisited

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Adjective Phrases

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- Complex noun phrases contain sentences or verb phrases as sub-components.
- Many nouns may take complements. Many of these require complement as preposition phrase.
Example: noun love has a complement form PP[of]: “their love of France”.
- Many nouns take infinitive VP form as complement.
Example: “his desire to release the guinea pig”.



Nouns

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Nouns may take the S[inf] as complement:

Example: “my hope for John to open the case again”.

Noun phrases can also be built out of clauses:

- that clause (S[that]) can be used as subject of the a sentence: “That John had the ring was surprising”.
- forms of verb phrase VP[inf], S[inf] and gerundive VP[ing] và S[ing] can also be as noun phrases:

Example:

- “To own a car would be delightful”;
- “For us to complement a project on time would be unprecedented”

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Example:

- “Giving up the game was unfortunate”;
 - “John’s giving up the game caused a riot”.
- + Relative clauses involve sentence forms used as modifiers in noun phrases. These relative clause often begins relative pronoun such as who, which, what, and so on.

Example:

“The man who gave Bill the money. . .”.

“The rug that George gave to Mary. . .”.

“The man whom George gave the money to..”



Adjective Phrases

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More complex adjective phrases also possible as adjectives take many of the same complement forms that occur with verbs. This includes specific prepositional phrases as PP[with], PP[at], S[that], VP[inf].

Example:

“Jack was pleased with the pizza”

“Jack was angry at the committee”

“Jack was angry that he was left behind”

“Jack seemed willing to lead the chorus”



Adjective Phrases (cont.)

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+ adjective phrases may take degree modifier preceding the head.

Example: “very angry”; “somewhat fond of Mary”; “far too heavy”; “much more desperate”.



Adverbial Phrases

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Adverb may occur in several positions in the sentences; in the sentence initial position, in the verb sequence, in the sentence final position.

+ Such adverbial phrases, however usually cannot occur except in the sentence initial or sentence final position.



Adverbial Phrases (cont.)

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Adverbial phrases (ADVPs) are useful considered by function rather than syntactic form. We can consider manner, temporal, duration, location, degree, and frequency adverbial phrases.

- Temporal adverbials: particles (for example: now); noun phrase (today, yesterday); preposition phrase (at noon, during the fight), clause (when the clock struck noon, before the lunch started).
- Frequency adverbials: particles (often); noun phrase (every day); preposition phrase (at every party), clause (every time that John comes for a visit).



Adverbial Phrases (cont.)

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- Duration adverbials: most appear commonly as prepositional phrases (for three hours, about 20 feet), clause (until the moon turns blue).
- Manner adverbials: occur in a wide range of forms. They include particles (slowly), noun phrase (this way), preposition phrase (in great haste), and clause (by holding the embers at the end of a stick)



Thank you!